

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

Have you ever wondered what we're made out of? Stars apparently. Head to Infoporn to find out how. Then in Alt feature take a look at big-shot companies trolling each other. Finally, in 1000-words, check out some really weird (but photogenic) trees.



The plague of buzzwords

One of the core competencies in modern offices is to use all kinds of buzzwords, which dress up less palatable words. You "pivot" after you mess up, you "sync up" through an argument, and struggling to make something work is "growth hacking". Maybe overusing industry jargon is just a way for workers to pretend to be adulting. <https://dgit.in/buzzkill>

WHAT'S NEW

The glass box that changed the world

Around the year 1833, the English botanist Dr Nathaniel Bagshaw Ward got a carpenter to make a close fitting glass box to grow ferns. The idea came about after he noticed that a fern spore had managed to bloom in a sealed glass jar containing a cocoon. Till that point in time, no one had thought of challenging the prevailing notion that plants can only grow in the open air. Essentially, Ward had come up with the precursor to the modern terrarium, and the design proved to be the starting point of the aquarium as well. The glazed cases allowed for transportation of plants across sea voyages. Previously, the plants would die if kept below decks for lack of exposure to sunlight, or die from exposure to the salty sea spray



above deck. The wardian cases allowed for transportation of plants across the British empire. Rubber plants from Brazil were transported for plantations in Sri Lanka and Malay. The English also managed to transport tea from China to India after the

first opium war. The cinchona tree was transported from South America to Sri Lanka. The bark contained quinine, which offered protection against malaria. Without this, some historians believe that Africa would not have been colonised.

<https://dgit.in/wrdncs>

How well do face masks prevent disease spread?

The face mask that you are wearing may not actually be that good at preventing the spread of infectious diseases. N95 Respirators are masks that are certified to be able to block over 95 percent of particles that are smaller than 0.3 microns. Only a few of these certified products are available to the general public, and the versions that are available are not recommended for healthcare workers treating patients



with infectious diseases. The N95 respirators for healthcare workers are single use, disposable masks. They are trained on how to wear and remove them, and the masks are also fit tested to ensure that there

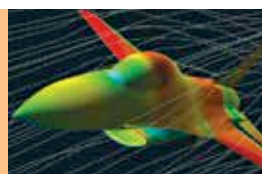
is no spread of infection. There is a particular way to wear the mask as well, you have to tighten the straps to ensure that it fits perfectly on your face. Even while wearing it, one has to be careful about the mask. The purpose of the mask is defeated if you touch the front of the mask or the filters, as it is possible that you can get contaminated by the particles there.

<https://dgit.in/facemasks>



How Facebook ads track you offline

Brick and mortar stores are getting pretty good at tracking people's habits and movements. From apps that allow location tracking to the free WiFi hotspots in shopping malls, data on users are gathered, which are then used to target ads on Facebook. <https://dgit.in/fbads1>



Nobody knows how planes fly

While there are complex mathematical equations that allow aerospace engineers to design planes, the underlying science on exactly why a plane generates lift is not fully understood. There are two main competing theories, but no consensus, and neither are a complete explanation. <https://dgit.in/howfly>



Blind people don't become schizophrenics

While the fact is well known in the mental health community, scientists are only now beginning to investigate exactly why no person who was born blind has ever been diagnosed with schizophrenia. Those who go blind later in life, are not similarly protected. <https://dgit.in/blindschizo>